in 2025. Heavy rain was common to both; here the toll was concentrated at one spot due to milling crowds, a claimed announcement that the pandal might collapse, and a congested exit.

Various accounts went around; the CM, too, visited the site and joined the chorus of descriptions. A Special Investigation Team has been set up, led by retired Justice Anindita Roy Saraswati. Seven people were arrested, including some organising committee members. But what also came under focus was the prequel. For, Chorebagan Sarbojanin—a prominent north Kolkata pujo—had seen a significant transition with the BJP's ascent to power.



Takeaways

- **Pandal stampede leaves 19 dead, 25 hurt in Kolkata**
- **New idol theme had drawn huge crowds**
- **BJP faces had taken over at puja committee**

WIND OF CHANGE

It wasn't a light affair. The first *khunti* puja for pandal construction had been held on July 5. BJP leaders like Locket Chatterjee and Kaustav Bagchi came. Biman Saha was named as the artist. The theme was Akal Bodhan (the Untimely Awakening of Durga), an episode where Rama worships the goddess. The Puranic basis for the 16th-18th century shift of Durga veneration from spring to autumn, it should have sat well with the present.

However, on July 17, veteran general secretary Jayanta Banerjee, his daughter Pratyusha and the rest of the committee resigned, paving the way for a new management. It included North Kolkata BJP chief Tamoghna Ghosh as chief advisor, Jorasanko BJP MLA Bijay Ojha as chairman and Debdeep Adhikari, the CM's nephew, as chief patron.

A NEW KIND OF DURGA

A second *khunti* puja followed on July 29. The art also changed. Sushanta Shibani Paul replaced Saha. The new theme, 'Orob'—the Bengali rendering of 'Arav' or 'soundless'—saw an iconographic shift from the festive to the meditative. Instead of a lion, Durga sat on a crescent moon; Mahishasura, instead of being slayed, is in peaceful surrender. The redesign drew curious throngs, eventually shattering its own intended peace. Now, it's a raging political war, with Mamata All India Trinamool Congress alleging a forcible ouster of the old management and seeking scrutiny of the CM's family connections.

BJP state chief Samik Bhattacharya sought to distance himself from the goings-on, saying he was mentally devastated by the tragedy. He said he had understood the CM's nephew to be a minor and didn't know how he figured in the reshuffle. In the run-up to Pujo, Bhattacharya had called for ruling party members to not insinuate themselves in committees. Meanwhile, CM Adhikari visited the families of many victims and handed over financial assistance.

The CPI(M) accused the administration of misplaced priorities. Party leaders like Mohammed Salim questioned the deployment of police personnel to dismantle a Left-affiliated bookstall after the tragedy—the other incident that made it to the week's headlines. ■

KERALA

Pinarayi's Red Diary Trouble

The ex-CM gets a breather from SC, but his battle against a posse of probe agencies is far from over

By **Jeemon Jacob**

PINARAYI VIJAYAN, LEADER OF OPPOSITION, presumably never read 20th-century French criminologist Dr Edmond Locard. Nor his daughter T. Veena and son-in-law P.A. Mohamed Riyas. Had they read him, a key piece of evidence claimed by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) would not have existed. Locard had a simple formulation: every contact leaves a trace. The ED's Kochi unit says it has found several in the 'Exalogic bribery case'. Among them, payments allegedly made to Veena—for no services offered, and without supporting invoices—over 10 months in 2017 by Co-



IN THE CROSSHAIRS Former Kerala CM Pinaryai Vijayan's daughter Veena